BEYOND THE VELVET ROPES

My Story of Perseverance, Hope, and Love

The opening — a gift from
Jennifer Walcott Archuleta

He drove me into the desert, handed me a shovel, and told me to dig.

My hands shook with every scoop. The night air was cold enough to sting. The shovel blistered my palms as I clawed at the packed earth — every scrape of metal on rock echoing in my ears like a countdown. Dust rose bitter into my throat. My arms shook so badly I could barely lift it. But I kept going. What choice did I have?

This is it, I thought. This is how I die.

Each scoop felt like I was burying pieces of myself. I waited for the moment he'd push me in.

It never came. Hours later he drove me home and acted like burying me alive had been a game.

A small-town girl from Ohio, digging her own grave in the desert — and he was still calling it love.

I'm still here. This is the story of how.

But to understand how I ended up in that desert, you have to go back to the beginning — to the small-town girl who was told exactly what she'd never be.

CHAPTER ONE

More Than a Small-Town Girl

“Your first hometown always fits in your pocket, small enough to carry everywhere you go, yet forever big enough to remind you who you truly are.”

When I was nine years old, we had a kitchen and a living room, and that was the house. In the living room there was a tan swivel chair, and I would sit in it and watch the Weather Channel the way other kids watched cartoons.

I’d turn the chair toward the screen and wait for the map to swing west, wait for Los Angeles to come up with that impossible number next to it — seventy-some degrees in the middle of a Youngstown February. I’d spin a little in the chair and wonder what it would be like to live somewhere it was always warm. No tornadoes. No storms. Not gloomy and gray for half the year. I remember thinking it the way a kid thinks anything, plain and certain: why would I stay here? You didn’t have to be a rocket scientist to figure out you could live somewhere else and have a better life, just because of the weather. I had never been on a plane. I had barely been out of Ohio. But I knew, the way you know your own name, that some of that sky had my name on it.

I was born in Youngstown on May 8, 1977. It’s a steel town about sixty miles from Cleveland and the same from Pittsburgh, halfway between Chicago and New York and nowhere near either. By the time I came along the mills were mostly closing and the paychecks were getting smaller, but the town still had its

blue-collar backbone and wasn't about to put it down. Sixty-five thousand people, and it felt like sixty-five. Everybody knew your name and your family and your business before you walked in the door. Some days that closeness felt like everybody was watching and waiting on you. Other days it was the only thing holding you up. In my family it was usually both at the same time.

In Ohio you only get a few months of real sunshine a year, so people take it while it's here. The second the weather turns, everybody is outside — washing cars, cutting grass, walking, working out, doing all the things they couldn't do all winter, and you can tell they're enjoying every minute because they know how short it is. I still remember the birds early in the morning and again in the evening, and how that was somehow such a beautiful sound. The smell of cut grass and the gas off the lawn mower. The sun finally on your face. Summer in our neighborhood meant racing bikes down the sidewalks until the streetlights came on and somebody's mom yelled it was time. Our hangout was the Taco Bell a block from the house, where the tacos were less than a dollar and half the kids we knew showed up on bikes just to have somewhere to be. When you only get good weather a few months a year, you don't waste a minute of it. That's really where it started for me — not with a plan, just a kid in a swivel chair who couldn't understand why anybody would choose to stay somewhere so gloomy half the year when there was a place the sun came out every single day.

My mother worked late nights, so a lot of mornings she slept in and I got myself up and out. I'd wake up late, throw myself together, get my baby brother his bottle, write my mom a note, and make her coffee — even though by the time she got to it she'd have to warm it back up. Then I'd walk to the bus stop and

wait. I can still smell the leather of that school bus, and I can still see every person who got on it, the ones you hated and the ones you liked, in the same order every day.

And then there was school, where I want to be honest with you about something I didn't have a name for yet. I would sit in class trying to take science notes and catch myself thinking about what I had to pack for ballet. Whether my brothers would need babysitting that night. Half the time I genuinely didn't know what day it was. The clock would be ticking somewhere behind me, pencils tapping all around me, the teacher talking the whole time — and it sounded like the adults in Charlie Brown, that wah-wah-wah, all the meaning scrubbed out of the words. One day a teacher looked up and asked me what I was writing down for the notes. I looked up at her with a blank stare. She was still talking and I didn't know what she was saying. I wasn't being lazy and I wasn't being a brat. I just wasn't in the room, even though I was sitting right there in it. I didn't have a word for that then. The word, when it finally came years later, was ADHD, and another one came with it: anxiety. But you don't get the words when you're a kid. You just get the cloud, and the feeling that you're working twice as hard as the kid next to you to end up in the same place, or behind. Animals were my first safe place from all of it. A dog named Scooby, stray cats I always swore found me and not the other way around. For years I wanted to be a veterinarian. I wanted to learn. It was never the wanting that failed me.

My parents divorced when I was four. They had fought a lot before that. I know that now — I didn't know it then, because when you're a kid you don't know what's normal and what isn't. You just live in it. What I remember is not understanding any of

it. Where would Dad go? Where would we go? Would we still see him? They're not going to be together anymore — what does that even mean? What does that look like? I couldn't wrap my brain around it no matter how many times I turned it over. It was so hard that for a long time the only prayer I had at night was the same one, every single night: Dear God, can you please let my parents get back together?

He didn't. They didn't. And that was the first big thing I ever learned about love — that the people you need can be in one house and then in two, and you'll spend a lot of nights praying. Four isn't too little for that to land. Four is exactly old enough to start keeping a quiet list of who makes you feel safe, so you can stay close to them.

Top of that list was my sister. Holly was eighteen months older than me, and for most of our childhood we shared a bedroom that barely fit two beds and a dresser, so we fought over it like it was land we both had a claim to. There was the time over the TV — she wanted to watch something, I told her she couldn't, and she told me that since the door was on her side of the room I wasn't allowed to leave it. We went back and forth forever, both of us drawing a line in the carpet that neither of us could explain or back down from, until I solved it the only way that made sense at the time and climbed out the window. My mom walked in while I had one leg out of the house and asked, fair enough, what exactly we thought we were doing.

And then there was the compact. Holly and I both had CoverGirl compacts, the expensive kind, and I can still smell them — they had their own specific smell, and peeling the little plastic film off a new one was like uncovering gold. We got into it over

something. To this day I don't know exactly what — maybe I took her compact by accident, or a lipstick, or maybe I was wearing something of hers — but it ended with her throwing the compact on the ground, and it shattered into a million pieces, powder everywhere. We were both furious and both heartbroken, and then we had to just leave it there on the floor and rush off to school. That night we still weren't talking. We lay there in our beds, back to back, in the dark, neither one of us giving an inch. And then one of us started talking about her day at school. And then we were both laughing.

That's the truest thing I can tell you about my sister and me. Every fight we ever had ended the same way — back to back, in the dark, and then one of us starts talking about nothing, and the fight just forgets to keep going. There were seven of us in a two-bedroom house at one point. My brothers, Bryan and Shaun, are technically half-brothers — a word I have never once said out loud about them, because they were my brothers and that was the end of it. Holly and I split them between us and looked after them like they were ours, because in all the ways that counted on a regular Tuesday, they were. I was the one getting a bottle ready before the school bus came.

When we got in trouble, my mother's way of handling it was to talk. She would keep us at that kitchen table for hours. My sister and I used to joke — quietly, never where she could hear it — that we wished she would just hit us instead of lecturing us for hours. And honestly, half of what she said didn't stick, because my mind was already three rooms away and I had things to do and the last thing I wanted was to be sitting there. I'd roll my eyes. I'd pick at my nails. I'd sit there and act like I was listening when I wasn't.

But here is what that same woman did with the little she had. She worked nights and still made the holidays feel like something. At Christmas she baked sugar cookies and let us wreck them with colored candies, and we strung popcorn on a thread to hang on the tree like it was the most important job in the house. My father had his own version of it — every single Valentine's Day he showed up with one of those beautiful big velvet hearts full of candy. They made those days feel big anyway, out of cookies and popcorn thread and one of those velvet hearts, and I never once knew the difference.

And one thing she said to me went all the way in and never left, and I say it to my own kids now. There was a teacher, once, who was terrible to me — I'll get to her — and I had to sit at that table and tell my mother everything that happened. What she said back to me was this: if you tell the truth, and it has to be the truth, I will go to war for you. Whether she liked what she was hearing or she didn't. Truth first. And then she was on your side, all the way. She didn't leave any room between us. I didn't have the words for what that gave me back then. I do now. It was safety.

We were middle class, or close to it, depending on who was doing the measuring and how generous they felt that day. Next to Canfield or Boardman, Youngstown could look rough. It never felt like we were going without. I felt like a South Side kid, and I wore that like it was something you had to earn, because where I came from it was. "Y-Town is my town," people said, and they meant it.

My father worked long hours at a plastics plant, and the weekends were his. He filled them up so we'd have something to

remember — Idora Park, Geauga Lake, rib burn-offs with the smoke hanging in the hot summer air and some local band playing in a parking lot. The lake was its own thing. What I remember most is how much thought he put into it. He planned that cooler like it mattered — what we'd have for lunch, the drinks we didn't actually buy because Mom didn't allow soda and we couldn't really afford things like that anyway. He'd come pick us up, and he'd make sure the air in the tube was just right and there was enough gas in the boat and the suntan lotion was packed, and we'd stay out there until the sun went all the way down. To this day, the smell of Hawaiian Tropic puts me right back on that water. Here's the thing I didn't have words for as a kid: he loved it just as much as we did. It was an escape for him too. Out on the water, sun on your face, nobody able to reach you. He put all of that thought into that cooler. That was how he loved us.

Two tired people, in two different houses, both showing up however they could for their kids, and neither one of them keeping score out loud. Nobody ever sat me down and explained sacrifice to me. I just watched it happen up close for eighteen years.

I was a strange, happy mix — a tomboy and a pageant girl in the same skin. One afternoon I'd be tubing behind my Uncle Jim's boat with Holly screaming behind me and my dad at the wheel; the next I'd be at the ballet barre, or hunched over a notebook writing poetry I didn't show anyone. I made the cut for Western Reserve Ballet Company. We couldn't afford the tuition, so that was that, and I didn't make it a tragedy, because in my house you didn't. You found the next thing and you went and did it. In the winter we stayed outside until our hands went numb and

somebody made us come in. Some nights, when it was warm, I'd end up on Grandpa and Grandma Viglione's porch swing with a glass of sweet tea, the cicadas going in the dark, my grandfather not saying much. Over on the Walcott side, my other grandfather sat in the living room with football on the one screen and a headset on so he could hear a second game at the same time, while Grandma W. made pasta by hand in the kitchen. Faith, family, food, and football. Those were the four corners.

Holidays and Sundays like that were the best of us. Every Easter my grandmother Viglione sewed our outfits by hand to match our dolls, and we wore them to church like we were somebody. Those dresses weren't just clothes. They were her love you could put on. And there was a girl named Stacy. By high school it was me, Stacy, and our friend Gina, inseparable, but Stacy was the one I told things to — my secrets, my doubts, the size of the life I was already planning to go get, which she never once laughed at for being too big. She wasn't really a friend so much as a second sister, the one who made a small town feel survivable. Years later her story would take a turn none of us saw coming, and I will tell you that story, because she earned the right to have it told and I earned the scar of telling it. But not here. Here, let her be what she was — the person who made me believe the life I kept picturing was real, and mine, and something I could actually reach.

I didn't grow up wishing I was somewhere else. Not really. I want to be clear about that because the rest of this book is going to get hard, and I need you to know where it started. I wished I had more of both my parents — Mom was always working, I saw Dad on the weekends — but I never once doubted they were doing the best they could with what they had. We didn't have

much. We had enough. Enough love, enough noise, enough stubbornness to keep the whole thing standing.

I didn't grow up thinking I was missing something. I grew up thinking I had to go figure it out. And that hunger — running my own mornings, never sitting still, the map swinging west every time I dropped into that swivel chair — was the thing that would put me in a car with five hundred dollars and no real plan, driving three thousand miles away from the only place I'd ever lived.

This is where the sample ends.

How that small-town girl ended up in the desert with a shovel — and how she clawed her way out alive — is the rest of the story.

The magazine covers. The velvet-rope rooms. The love that nearly buried her. The faith that brought her back.

Read the whole story →
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